D'var Torah on Parshas Vayishlach: Standing in Front

Introduction: The Unique Message of Every Parsha

This week's Parsha, Parshas Vayishlach, has a profound message. Obviously, I say that about every Parsha, every Chag. And it's very much true, every single time. Because each Parsha has a unique message, and each time you read it, the message will be different, hopefully growing and enhancing with every step of the way.

The journey of Torah study is one of constant renewal. Each reading brings new depth, new understanding, new relevance to our lives.

The Meaning of Vayishlach: Sending Forward

The word Vayishlach means "and he sent out." The Torah opens with this word (Bereishis 32:4): "וישלח יעקב מלאכים לפניו אל עשו אחיו," And Yaakov sent messengers ahead of him to Eisav his brother.

The flow of this week's Parsha, and quite often in life, means we're sending something forward of us. In this situation, you see that Yaakov sends out malachim to check in on his brother, to do the best of his ability to ensure that he would have safety.

But there's a deeper question here: Why now? Why is Yaakov ready to face Eisav at this particular moment?

The Prerequisite: Yosef's Birth

If you look at last week's Parsha, when Yaakov prepares to leave Lavan, the Torah tells us (Bereishis 30:25): "ויהי כאשר ילדה רחל את יוסף," And it was when Rachel gave birth to Yosef. Rashi explains on this pasuk that it wasn't until Yosef was born that Yaakov was ready to leave and eventually face Eisav.

Why? Because Yosef was the only one who would have the koach to take on Eisav. The Midrash (Bereishis Rabbah 73:7) teaches that Yosef is compared to fire, while Eisav is compared to straw: "והיה בית יעקב אש ובית יוסף להבה ובית עשו לקש," The house of Yaakov will be fire, the house of Yosef a flame, and the house of Eisav like straw (Ovadiah 1:18).

Now that Yaakov has Yosef, now that he has the one who can spiritually take on Eisav, he sends out scouts, he sends out malachim to look at the reality of the situation before any confrontation comes. This is strategic preparation, gathering intelligence before action.

The Terrifying Message

And what message do the malachim bring back? The Torah records (Bereishis 32:7): " וישבו המלאכים אל יעקב לאמר באנו אל אחיך אל עשו וגם הלך לקראתך וארבע מאות איש עמו," The messengers returned to Yaakov saying, "We came to your brother, to Eisav, and he is also coming toward you, and four hundred men are with him."

"Sir, I have some good news and some bad news. The good news is that your brother wants to see you. The bad news is it's because he wants to kill you. And he has an army 400 strong." It's a terrifying message to receive.

The Torah continues (Bereishis 32:8): "וַיִּירָא יַעֲקֹב מְאֹד וַיֵּצֶר לו," And Yaakov became very frightened and distressed. Rashi explains the double language: he was frightened that he might be killed, and distressed that he might have to kill others.

Now, Rashi, who always goes with the simplest explanation, the pshat, says that these malachim were literally angels, not any other sort of messenger. But when we look at the messaging here, what happened? Is it that Yaakov sent out malachim to keep himself safe? No. He sent out malachim to see and to scope out the situation, to gather information.

The Three-Pronged Approach

Yaakov's response to the threat is methodical and comprehensive. The mefashim teach that Yaakov prepared himself in three ways: "בשלשה דברים תיקן עצמו: בדורון, בתפילה, ובמלחמה," In three things he prepared himself: with gifts, with prayer, and with war.

The Torah describes each of these preparations in detail. First, the gifts (Bereishis 32:14-21), carefully selected and sent in waves to appease Eisav. Second, the prayer (Bereishis 32:10-13), where Yaakov calls out to Hashem: "הצילני נא מיד אחי מיד עשו כי ירא אנכי אתו," Save me please from the hand of my brother, from the hand of Eisav, for I fear him. And third, the preparation for war, dividing his camp so that at least some would survive.

But the most crucial moment comes not in planning, but in action.

Wrestling with the Angel: A Test of Strength

As we move forward in the Parsha, something extraordinary happens. A man wrestles with Yaakov all night long. The Torah describes (Bereishis 32:25-26): " ויאבק איש עמו עד עלות השחר. וירא כי לא יכל לו," And a man wrestled with him until the break of dawn. And when he saw that he could not prevail against him.

Rashi explains that this "man" was the ministering angel of Eisav, the spiritual force behind Eisav's physical power. The wrestling match wasn't just physical; it was spiritual warfare. And Yaakov prevailed.

The angel then says (Bereishis 32:27): "שלחני כי עלה השחר," Send me away, for dawn has broken. But Yaakov refuses to let go without a blessing. The angel responds by changing his

name (Bereishis 32:29): "לא יעקב יאמר עוד שמך כי אם ישראל כי שרית עם אלקים ועם אנשים ותוכל," No longer will your name be called Yaakov, but Yisrael, for you have struggled with the divine and with men, and you have prevailed.

This is the moment of transformation. Yaakov becomes Yisrael. He has the bracha, he has the strength, he has prevailed over the angel of Eisav himself. He is ready.

Standing in Front: The Ultimate Leadership

And now comes the moment of truth. When Yaakov finally meets his brother, the Torah tells us something powerful (Bereishis 33:3): "והוא עבר לפניהם," And he passed before them.

Yaakov's priorities and his realities were clear. Even knowing he has a bracha from Hashem, even knowing he got a bracha from an enemy angel that he was able to fight, even knowing his strength and his balance, he also knows his brother wants to kill him. And what does he do?

He doesn't hide behind his wives. He doesn't hide behind his children. He doesn't send someone else forward. Instead, he stands in front of everybody else. He went in front.

It's no longer a situation of vayishlach, that he sends forward somebody else. The time for sending scouts has passed. The time for preparation is over. Now is the time for action, for leadership, for standing at the head.

It's not just a level of mesiras nefesh, a willingness to give up one's life. He's ready to stand and fight. The Midrashim teach: if someone needs to fall, that'll be me. But not that I want to fall instead of anybody else. I'm going to be here, I'm going to go forward, I'm going to stand straight. I know what to fight for.

Rashi brings another beautiful insight on the words "והוא עבר לפניהם," explaining that Yaakov bowed seven times as he approached his brother, corresponding to the seven times the word "אדוני," my master, appears in his message to Eisav. He humbled himself, but he stood in front. He led with dignity and with strategy.

The Precedent of Avraham: Fighting for Values

We see this pattern earlier in our history. By Avraham, when he went to fight to liberate Lot (Bereishis 14:14-16), the Torah records: "וישמע אברם כי נשבה אחיו," And Avram heard that his kinsman was taken captive. What follows is a military campaign to rescue Lot from the four kings who had captured him.

The Midrash (Bereishis Rabbah 41:6) explains something fascinating: what was Avraham really fighting for? Was it just Lot? According to this Midrash, Avraham and Lot looked identical, or nearly identical. And so what was Avraham fighting for?

He was fighting for his own value system and his name. If they had succeeded in breaking Lot and getting Lot to go back to serving avodah zarah and then dying in that state, the word would

have spread around the world that Avraham had failed. Because even though it wasn't Avraham, they looked the same.

Avraham would stand up and fight for what was right, even if he would fall in the process. Better that he would fall in battle, and everyone knows the truth, than to have Lot fall after giving in to avodah zarah and have everybody think that Avraham and his message stood for nothing.

This is the legacy of our Avos: standing up for values, for truth, for what is right, even at great personal risk.

Throughout Our History: Leaders Who Stood in Front

We see so many times throughout Tanach, we see it in stories of the Gemara, about Jews, about Yidden, about Bnei Yisrael, willing to put up the fight. Sometimes it's a verbal fight. Sometimes it's a physical fight. But always, the leader stands at the head.

Moshe Rabbeinu put himself out there as the head when Hashem wanted to wipe out Bnei Yisrael after the sin of the Golden Calf. The Torah records his prayer (Shemos 32:32): "ועתה אם תשא חטאתם ואם אין מחני נא מספרך אשר כתבת," And now, if You would forgive their sin, and if not, erase me now from Your book that You have written.

He said, "No, I'm not going to take over for them. I'm not going to replace them. Remove me from Your book as well. You will wipe out my name if You're going to take out these people." This is leadership: standing with your people, not above them.

The head, the rosh, the leader, knows that they're supposed to be leading by being at the head. We all live our lives this way. We lead our life by our head. At first, we use our head, we use our brain, and we make sure that takes precedence.

Esther HaMalka prepared herself to go before the king, where people would die every time for appearing uninvited, including her own predecessor, Queen Vashti. The Megillah records (Esther 4:16): "וכאשר אבדתי אבדתי," And if I perish, I perish. She went in ready to fight for her people, by standing in charge, by taking control, knowing that her job as a leader was to do these things.

Mordechai HaTzaddik, we see as well, was willing to stand up and give up his life instead of bowing before the wicked Haman. The Megillah tells us (Esther 3:2): "ומרדכי לא יכרע ולא ישתחוה," But Mordechai would not kneel or bow. When questioned, he stood firm in his principles, knowing it could cost him his life.

The Chashmonaim during the time of Chanukah stood up, saying, "No, I'm not going to give in to the Greeks. I will do what is right." They were few against many, weak against strong, but they stood at the head and led the Jewish people back to Torah and to Hashem.

And in today's world, too, we see where Bnei Yisrael is willing to fight for their values, fight for what is right, and to know that they, as individuals, need to stand there and be a strong leader.

As a head, I'm supposed to be in front of my body. I'm supposed to lead with my head and keep the rest of me safe. It seems almost contradictory, but it is a true statement: by placing ourselves in front, by taking the risk, we actually protect what is most precious to us.

A Lesson from the Street: Instinctual Protection

I want to share a small story. The idea behind the story is not to be degrading towards this person, but there's wisdom and insight that we can learn from our own responses, our own natural responses to the world around us.

The other day, I was walking my dog. There was a woman walking with her husband, pushing a stroller. Now, most parents, almost all parents, would give up their lives for their children. This woman, seeing my dog, jumped behind the stroller to put the stroller, really put her baby, in between my dog and herself.

Now, those who know my dog know her better. She weighs about eight and a half pounds, 4.1 kilos. She is not much. And she's old, she's missing about half of her teeth. This woman doesn't know that my dog doesn't have all her teeth, or that she's old.

But an instinct inside of her, the instinct of the average parent to be most beneficial to their child's life, to keep their children safe, something that we gain from the middos of the Avos. Part of those middos of the Avos we've spoken about, by Avraham, by Yitzchak, by Yaakov, is knowing how to give up ourselves to ensure everything afterwards goes forward.

But here's the fascinating thing: her instinct wasn't quite right, was it? She put her child in front of her, not behind her. She didn't stand between the perceived threat and her child; she put her child between herself and the threat.

But maybe her instinct was that far off.

There is something inside of us that is usually able to help us understand the difference, even if not logical, between what may kill that next generation versus what may harm. This is a deeper wisdom, a gift from Hashem.

As a parent, I never want my children to get hurt. An unfortunate reality of growing up is that people do get hurt. Children hit their heads on things. Hopefully, they're wearing a helmet if they're riding a bicycle. People who know me well know that I rant about helmet safety, and I have a dream of one day driving around with helmets just to hand them out to children, and even more so to adults who don't set a good example.

But we know that getting hurt, being harmed in life, is a reality. People get hurt. Our children get hurt. And God willing, they come out stronger because of it. That's the reason why we allow our children to walk, to run, to ride bicycles, to play games, and to learn how to do things. Because if we keep them completely coddled at all times and prevent them from ever getting hurt physically in any way, shape, or form, they can never grow.

The Gemara in Sotah (46b) teaches: "עולם כמנהגו נוהג," The world follows its natural course. Part of that natural course includes challenge, includes difficulty, includes the minor injuries of childhood that teach resilience and strength.

But instinctually, I know the difference between something where my child may get hurt versus my child will die. And the ability to then step forward and say, "No, I'm going to do my best to make sure that I survive whatever the fallout may be right now. But you are not going to end the life of my child. You are not going to stop or break that which I hold most precious and dear to me."

Whether that be a child, a belief structure, Torah, mitzvos, we have that within us as a gift from Hashem, a natural response of our neshama. Maybe even also a chelek of a higher insight that we get as being part of Bnei Yisrael.

This insight, this higher level, this is what tells us: I need to stand in front. My child may get smacked a little bit, but they're going to come out of this.

And kol hakavod to that woman who jumped to the other side of her child. There's something inside of her that knew no one's going to die, no one's going to get that badly hurt, and it's okay. Her instinct, even if her positioning was off, was fundamentally correct: assess the threat, and respond accordingly.

Refining Our Middos and Our Bodies

We all get to learn to listen to ourselves, to that inner wisdom. As Rabbi Gerzi teaches, we've been talking about our middos, we've been talking about our guf, our body. Our guf can also be responding to our middos.

The Alter Rebbe teaches in Tanya (Chapter 1) that the nefesh habahamis, the animal soul, is clothed in the blood and in the physical body. But as we refine our middos, as we work on ourselves spiritually, this has an impact on the physical as well.

As those of us who learn from Rabbi Gerzi learn as well, the more we grow, the more we change and impact our middos and refine them, the more that will then have an impact on our body. Our body becomes this more natural responsive engine that learns how to do the ratzon of Hashem. And then from that, that's going to bring our middos to a higher level as well which will then bring our body even higher yet.

It's a cycle of growth: spiritual refinement leads to physical refinement, which enables deeper spiritual refinement. The body and soul work together, each elevating the other.

Tying It All Together: The Name of the Parsha

We can tie all this back to the name of the Parsha: Vayishlach, "and he sent out."

He sent out for information. Why? To prepare himself, his middos, which were then able to prepare his guf. He was able to be working on his natural state of survival, and to say, "No, the survival of me as an individual doesn't matter as much as that which I hold most dear, that which I'm going to hold behind me."

So he was able to send forward those who gathered information. But when it came time to do, when it came time to potentially fight, to stand up for what is correct, Yaakov was able to do so.

He stood in front. He led with his head. He protected what was behind him.

The progression is clear:

1. **Vayishlach** - Send out scouts, gather information, prepare
2. **Vaye'avek** - Struggle and wrestle with challenges, gain strength
3. **Vaya'avor lifneihem** - Pass before them, stand in front, lead

This is the model for our own lives. We prepare, we struggle and grow through that struggle, and then we stand up and lead. We protect what matters most by placing ourselves at the head, by being willing to face the threat directly.

The Deeper Message: Knowing When to Stand

But there's an even deeper lesson here. Yaakov didn't always stand in front. For twenty years with Lavan, he bent, he accommodated, he accepted injustice. Why? Because the time wasn't right. He was building, preparing, growing his family.

Now, with his family behind him, with Yosef born, with the bracha from the angel, the time has come to stand. The time has come to say: enough. No more running. No more hiding. I will face this.

This is wisdom: knowing when to prepare and when to act. Knowing when to bend and when to stand firm. Knowing when to send others forward and when to go forward yourself.

Reflection and Growth

This week, as we read Parshas Vayishlach, we're invited to consider our own lives through this lens:

On Preparation:

- What situations in my life require more information before I act? Am I sending out "scouts" to understand the reality I'm facing?
- Have I been preparing myself spiritually and physically for the challenges I know are coming?
- Is there something I've been avoiding because I don't feel ready? What would it take for me to feel ready?

On Standing in Front:

- What do I hold most precious and dear? My family, my values, my beliefs, my community?
- Am I willing to stand in front to protect these things, or do I hide behind others?
- When was the last time I took a stand for something that mattered, even when it was difficult or risky?

On Growth:

- What middos do I need to refine to be the kind of leader who can stand in front when needed?
- How are my spiritual practices affecting my physical life? How is my physical discipline affecting my spiritual growth?
- Am I in a cycle of growth, where body and soul elevate each other, or am I stuck?

Closing Thought

Yaakov teaches us that true leadership isn't about being the strongest or the loudest. It's about knowing when to gather information and when to act. It's about standing in front when it matters most, protecting what we hold dear by placing ourselves at risk.

It's about the courage to face our fears, to wrestle with our challenges, and to emerge transformed, ready to stand at the head.

May we all merit to know when to prepare and when to act, when to send others forward and when to go forward ourselves. May we have the wisdom to distinguish between harm that builds and danger that destroys. And may we always have the courage to stand in front when it truly matters.

Have a wonderful Shabbos.